Narrative Design Document – Wizard Yan's Diary: The Remembrance Alchemy

Kamil Jarosz

Core narrative premise

Working narrative summary

In 18th-century Poland, the player takes the role of Rob, an otter-shaped familiar spirit summoned by the young wizard Yan. As they work together to uncover alchemical secret of resurrection, Rob begins recovering memories of a previous life as Robak, the legendary otter owned by Jan Chryzostom Pasek.

What begins as a student–teacher relationship gradually becomes a friendship, and Yan's tower becomes Rob's new home. But Rob's recovered memories complicate his sense of self: they reveal a life of companionship, captivity, escape, and death. As Rob questions whether he is Rob, Robak, or both, Yan confronts the reality that he is not Jan - and that resurrection may not be the right choice.

By the final act, the player has learned Rob's backstory and must decide what identity to embrace and whether to pursue resurrection. The ending is mechanically driven by the player's mastery of alchemy and memory system, where Rob's beliefs affect the ending.

Narrative pillars

Pillar 1: Memory vs identity

Narrative context: Rob carries memories of Robak, the otter who lived with Jan, but initially has no recollection of his past. As he recovers these memories, he begins to question whether he is Robak returned to life or a new being shaped by someone else's experience. His growing friendship with Yan gives him new memories that belong to him alone. Rob must decide how to understand the relationship between his inherited past and the person he has become.

Gameplay translation: The player discovers and investigates memories of Robak's past, gradually building a picture of his life with Jan and the events leading to his death. New discoveries and conversations with Yan can change how the player interprets these memories and what they believe about Rob's identity. The player's understanding of Rob,

Robak, and their relationship shapes the final choice: whether Rob becomes Robak, remains himself, or embraces both identities.

Pillar 2: Relationship and belonging

Narrative context: Rob and Yan begin as summoner and familiar, with Yan treating Rob as helper in his alchemical research. Over time, their relationship evolves into friendship. The tower gradually becomes a shared home, and Rob finds a place in Yan's life beyond his role as familiar. Through their experiences together, both learn to value their relationship.

Gameplay translation: The player develops Rob and Yan's relationship through conversations, shared experiences, and memories created during gameplay. Their dialogue reflects changes in their understanding of and feelings toward each other, from early misunderstandings to mutual trust and friendship. Decorating the tower with objects such as Rob's bed and toys allows the player to shape their shared living space and express a sense of belonging. These interactions give the relationship a tangible presence in both the narrative and the player's everyday activities.

Pillar 3: Powerlessness

Narrative context: Jan's story explores the pain of being unable to protect someone you love. When the king demands Robak, Jan initially refuses and even tries to trick the king, but ultimately gives his otter up under threat. Robak escapes captivity and tries to return home, only to die just before reaching Jan. Unable to accept his loss, Jan spends the rest of his life studying alchemy, hoping to return to that moment and change what happened. His research becomes an attempt to regain control over a past he cannot let go of.

Gameplay translation: Through Robak's recovered memories, the player pieces together Jan's relationship with Robak, his surrender to the king, and his grief after Robak's death. By investigating these memories and discussing them with Yan, the player can consider Jan's responsibility: whether he could have acted differently, whether he had any real alternatives, and whether his lifelong pursuit of alchemy can make up for his failure to protect Robak. The player is left to judge the limits of Jan's agency and the cost of spending a life trying to undo what cannot be undone.

Pillar 4: Perfectionism as maladaptation

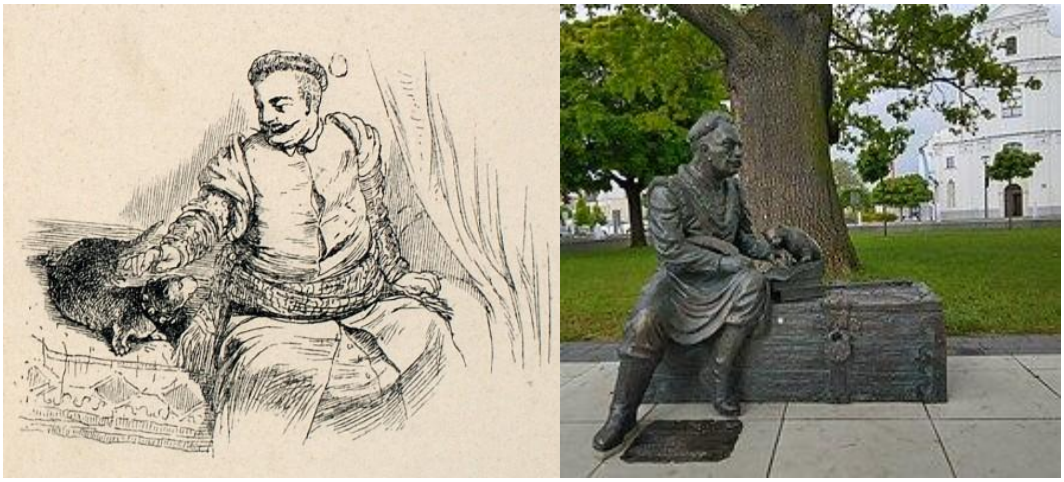
Narrative context: Yan's perfectionism stems from his fear of failure. He overanalyzes and hesitates to act unless he can be certain of success, trapping himself in his comfort zone and preventing him from making progress. Through his friendship with Rob, Yan gradually learns that experimentation and failure are necessary parts of discovery. He begins to accept uncertainty and take action without knowing whether his efforts will succeed.

Gameplay translation: Alchemy encourages player to experiment with different ingredient combinations to discover solutions. Failed experiments carry no penalty, reinforcing the idea that failure is a part of the learning process. Yan's character arc unfolds alongside this gameplay: his conversations with Rob reveal his changing attitude towards failure, while his progress in alchemy reflects his growing willingness to experiment, take risks and act without guarantees.

Chronological story - outline

The story is split into two halves: the past and the present.

The past is based on a Diaries (1690–1695) of Jan Chryzostom Pasek, a Polish sarmate who owned a pet otter Robak. In the game, it will be uncovered through memories.



One the left, illustration by Antoni Zaleski
On the right, Jan and Robak's monument in Rawa Mazowiecka.

The present story follows a familiar Rob and a young wizard Yan, experienced in the game through mechanics and narrative. It is structured around the six seasons of Poland: Early Spring, True Spring, Summer, Golden Autumn, Deep Autumn, and Winter. The game starts in Golden Autumn and ends the following Golden Autumn, making it 7 acts long.

The past

In 17th century Poland, Jan Chryzostom Pasek, encounters an otter while camping in a forest. He shares his fish with the animal, and the two gradually become inseparable. Jan names the otter Robak, and they travel together on the missions Jan undertakes for the king.

When the king demands Robak, Jan initially refuses to give him up. Threatened by the king, he eventually relents. Robak is taken to the royal manor and forced to wear a bell collar, which he despises. Heartbroken by their separation, Jan blames himself but feels powerless to challenge the king.

Robak eventually escapes and sets out to find Jan. After crossing forests, lakes and plains, he reaches Jan's home, only to be struck by an arrow from a hunter just before reaching the door. Jan rushed outside and witnesses Robak's final moments.

Consumed by grief and regret, Jan dedicates the rest of his life to alchemy, hoping to bring Robak back. Before his death, he records his research in The Remembrance Alchemy, leaving behind an unfinished work for someone in the future to complete.

The present

In 18th century, a young, ambitious wizard Yan moves into Jan's tower. The tower is mostly empty, with only a magical cauldron and Jan's book remaining. Intrigued by the unfinished research, Yan decides to complete it. However, he struggles to understand the book, and his perfectionism keeps him from attempting even a single experiment.

The present – Golden Autumn

Unable to make progress on Jan's research alone, Yan summons a familiar spirit to help him. The ritual brings back Robak's soul, still lingering around the tower, but the spirit has no memory of its former life. Yan names him Rob, unaware of his connection to Jan.

When Yan offers Rob half a fish, the gesture triggers Rob's first memory: an encounter with Jan. Neither understands its significance, and Yan dismisses it as a side effect of summoning.

With Rob's help, Yan attempts his first alchemical experiment. Rob discovers that he can perceive the elemental energies of ingredients, something Yan cannot do. When Yan hesitates, caught in his own analysis, Rob chooses an ingredient for him. The experiment succeeds, but Yan reacts with anger, calling Rob "just a dumb familiar, unaware of the consequences of his actions." He soon regrets his words and explains that he was afraid the experiment might put them both in danger.

Rob's ability to perceive elemental energy finally gives Yan a way to understand Jan's research. Together, they being exploring elemental space and using Jan's notes to locate new ingredients and discoveries. As they investigate the tower's surroundings, Rob discovers more fragments of Robak's memories. He begins to wonder whether he had a life before becoming Yan's familiar, and what that life might have been.

As Yan studies Jan's notes, he begins organizing open questions into alchemical examinations. He wants to verify their understanding of each chapter before moving on to the next one. Rob's elemental perception makes him an essential partner in those tests, which gradually become milestones in their progress through Jan's unfinished book.

The present – Deep Autumn

Yan sends Rob to the nearby river to gather more water-aligned ingredients. While exploring the riverbank, Rob discovers a memory of an otter fishing and playing in the water. The memory makes him wonder whether he had a life before Yan summoned him, and what that life might have been.

Meanwhile, Yan studies Jan's notes and works to understand the next stage of alchemy. His progress is slow because he wants to understand the system before committing to an experiment. Rob's ability to perceive elemental energy helps Yan understand how to expand their alchemical experiments into two-dimensional elemental space.

As Rob makes the tower his home, he discovers an otter bed through alchemy. Placing it in the tower starts a conversation with Yan about their living arrangements, reflecting the gradual shift in their relationship from summoner and familiar toward something more personal.

At the end of the season, Rob and Yan pass the alchemical examination for the second chapter. They celebrate with a meal, reflecting on how well they work together and how much progress they have made since their first experiment.

The present - Winter

Yan sends Rob to collect ingredients from the now-frozen river. While passing through the town, Rob hears the bell tower chime and talks to townspeople, who tell him stories about a king who kept an otter. The stories intrigue him, though he doesn't yet understand their connection to his own past.

As their alchemical work progresses, Yan begins to recognize how his perfectionism affects the research and Rob. One experiment produces a bell collar, triggering a memory of Robak's captivity at the king's manor. Rob begins to question his earlier idealized view of his past. Noticing Rob's distress, Yan tries to console him; though he doesn't know the full story behind Rob's memories.

After passing the third alchemical examination, Rob and Yan celebrate their progress together. Their partnership has grown since their first experiment, and Yan increasingly trusts Rob as an equal partner. Their celebration offers a welcome moment of warmth after Rob's troubling discovery about his past.

The present – Early Spring

Rob discovers memories of meeting Jan, sharing fish with him, travelling together, and protecting him. He begins to understand that Jan was someone he loved and trusted.

Yan continues making progress with The Remembrance Alchemy. Rob encourages him when he struggles, showing that their support is becoming mutual rather than one-sided.

Rob tells Yan he is proud of him. Yan apologizes for calling him a dumb familiar, acknowledges their friendship, and asks what objects Rob would like in their shared home. This is a significant step from treating Rob as a summoned helper to treating him as someone who belongs.

Together they tackle the fourth examination.

The present – True Spring

Rob travels to king's manor. Memories reveal that the king demanded Jan to hand over Robak to him. Rob realizes that Jan is not the king. Rob witnesses Robak's struggle to break free during the transport to the manor, how he bit king's hand upon arrival, how the king made him wear a bell collar, as well as the escape from the manor. The last memory shows Robak standing outside Jan's house and Jan opening the door to greet him. Rob believes that Yan summoned him at that exact moment, robbing him of finally returning to his beloved owner. He also wonders why Jan didn't fight for him or tried to rescue him from the manor.

Inspired by his own progress in alchemy, Yan reflects again on his perfectionism. Through an exchange with his inner critic, he realizes that it's better to try and fail than not to try at all. There's no other way to progress than through occasional failure. And failing itself also provides some new data to analyze. He says to his inner critic that he's grateful for trying to protect him, but he doesn't need him anymore. Yan wants to tell Rob he's changed his life, but Rob confronts him on stealing him from his owner, Jan. Yan responds that Jan is long gone. He documented his incomplete research in the book just before his death, hoping that someone in the future might finish it.

Aether zone discovered in the previous exam leads to a new layer of alchemy map, revealing new discoveries. Rob mourns the death of his owner but still can't believe he gave Robak away. Yan tries to cheer him up, revealing some discovery zones he found in Jan's book that were obviously meant for an otter companion – toy pebbles, magical waterhose, floating objects. He asks Rob if he remembers doing experiments with Jan and says that Jan must have really loved Robak.

The exam tests Rob's understanding of Aether zones, requiring discoveries from the new layer. The last question points to a descending Aether zone.

The present – Summer

Rob visits Jan's old home. Memories show that Robak was hit by an arrow, Jan ran outside to witness his Robak's final moments. Rob also witnesses the exchange between Jan and the king. The king threatens Jan, who's powerless and depressed after losing Robak. Revisiting already unlocked locations in summer yields some new ingredients. Rob reflects on the lifetime spent with Jan and new memories he made with Yan, questioning if he's Robak or Rob.

The descending Aether zone uncovers a new layer below the starting point.

Yan realizes Jan wanted to bring back Robak. He decides to continue his research, so that Rob can be resurrected. The new layer on the map contains a discovery area surrounded by impassable elemental zone. That's the final puzzle Jan couldn't solve. Yan reasons that there must be a way to bypass elemental zones somehow. He studies elemental energy of ingredients in hope of finding a solution. Yan is also seen reading medical books and sketching out otter's anatomy.

The exam asks Rob to explore the new layer. Passing the exam unlocks Aether processing mode for alchemical stations, which grant powerful options for late-game exploration.

The present – Golden Autumn

Rob discovers memories around the tower - of Jan building the tower, starting his research, his grief and frustration, working alone to bring back Robak, realizing he won't be able to complete his research and writing a book on his deathbed. Rob sympathizes with Jan. Even if he's resurrected, Jan is already gone. Will Rob keep Robak's and Rob's memories? Will he become a regular otter again, unable to see ingredients' energy or speak with Yan?

Yan's research on ingredients leads to discovery of magical monocle that allows him to see elemental energies, just like Rob. Looking at Rob, he notices he is giving off Aether energy. He hypothesizes that using him as an ingredient would allow for changing layers outside of Aether zones. This might be the way to reach the locked off discovery zone!

Reaching the discovery zone opens a wormhole, which displays a memory. Rob sees the other side and recognizes it immediately. It's his final memory before death. He sees Jan.

The Remembrance Alchemy

There is no resurrection alchemy. Haunted by the memory of Robak's death, Jan spends his life trying to return to that moment. His research preserves that memory, but he never managed to reach it.

Aether, the quintessence, can transcend boundaries. Because Rob carries Aether energy, using him as an ingredient allows Remembrance Alchemy to transform this preserved memory into a wormhole through time, granting access to Robak's final moments.

Whether Rob becomes Robak when entering the memory depends on his understanding of his own identity. If he believes himself to be Robak, he experiences Robak's final moments as his own. If he sees himself as distinct, he can witness the memory without becoming the otter, remaining a spirit.

Endings

The ending is mechanically driven. Throughout the game, Rob is collecting Robak's memories and creating new ones with Yan. When each memory is viewed, the player can respond to it in various ways, which shapes Rob's beliefs. If Rob identifies with Robak, he starts believing that he is Robak. If Rob identifies with Rob, he believes he is Rob. This creates four possibilities: (A) Robak, (B) Rob, (C) Robak and Rob, (D) neither. Depending on what Rob believes, a different ending is triggered. The player can reload a save before the finale and reassess Rob's beliefs to view other endings.

Ending A – Robak

Rob chooses to enter the wormhole alone. As he crosses its threshold, he becomes Robak, returning to the final moments of his past life. He experiences his death from first-person perspective, feeling the pain of his wound and the warmth of Jan holding him in his arms. For the first time, he can experience their final moments together as the otter Jan loved.

Robak dies in Jan's arms.

The cycle begins again. Overwhelmed by grief, Jan builds his tower and devotes his life to the Remembrance Alchemy, trying to return to the moment he lost Robak. He preserves the memory of their final moments in his research but never manages to reach it. After Jan's death, Yan eventually moves into the tower, discovers the unfinished research, and summons Rob.

Rob has chosen to become Robak again, accepting his death in exchange for one last moment with Jan. His choice leads to the same loss that started the cycle, and the events that brought him to Yan being anew.

Ending B – Rob

Rob and Yan witness the memory of Robak's final moments with Jan. Rob chooses to enter the memory. However, he does not become Robak.

Rob watches as Jan holds the dying otter in his arms, unable to do anything to change what happened. Robak died, and no amount of remembrance can undo his death. But as Rob watches Jan grieve, he comes to understand that Robak was loved.

Rob returns to Yan. The past is still part of him, but it does not define who he is. Looking at the alchemical equipment and the decorations they've created and placed in the tower, Rob recognizes the life they built together.

"I am here."

Rob chooses the present and remains Rob, no longer searching for belonging in a life that has already ended.

Ending C – Robak and Rob

Rob and Yan enter the wormhole together. Rob becomes Robak, experiencing his final moments with Jan firsthand, but he remains Rob. His past and present are no longer mutually exclusive.

Yan believes he may be able to save Robak. He has spent the summer studying otter anatomy, hoping to find a way to intervene in the memory. When Yan catches up to Jan and the dying otter, he realizes that he cannot know whether his plan will work.

"No."

He hesitates, takes a breath, and looks at Robak.

"But we have to try."

Together with Jan, they attempt to save the dying otter. The screen fades. When the scene returns, Robak is alive. Jan offers him a fish, and the otter eats half before nudging the rest toward Yan.

Rob remembers him.

Ending D – Neither

Rob and Yan witness the memory of Robak's final moments with Jan. Rob recognizes the otter as someone he once believed himself to be.

After witnessing Robak's death, Rob realizes that his role as Yan's familiar has come to an end. He decided to leave.

One day, Yan discovers that Rob is gone. He searches the tower, then ventures outside, looking for any sign of his companion. As he searches, a memory of an earlier conversation plays in the background; Rob telling Yan that one day, he will disappear.

Yan keeps looking, but he does not find Rob.

Eventually, he returns to the tower. His research remains unfinished on the desk. He sits down and resumes his work, no longer the alchemist who was too afraid of failure to begin.

Rob is gone, but the time they spent together has changed Yan. He continues living, carrying their friendship with him, even without knowing why Rob left or whether he will return.